



ENGPRA ASSIGNMENT 2

The reality of English as the “lingua franca” of tech
while most developers are non-native speakers

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Introduction

As cybersecurity students at HSLU, Cyrill and I selected Topic B because English is the absolute foundation of our daily lives as developers. We worked highly individually, utilizing a shared Word document and communicating through short, clear Teams messages. When evaluating Cyrill's working style through Erin Meyer's Culture Map, our collaboration was defined by a structured Swiss cultural framework paired with the realities of working in a second language. On the communicating scale, Cyrill is strictly low-context; he prefers explicit, direct information, though he sits at a crossroads as a non-native speaker who needs extra time to process and express himself in English. This deliberate pace translated perfectly into our trusting and scheduling scales, which were heavily task-based and linear. He built trust through efficient, lean, asynchronous inputs that kept our project organized, highlighting the balance global teams must strike between speed and inclusiveness.

Cultural Alignment & Adjustment

During the planning and research phase of our project, a notable shift occurred in our dynamic that required me to step out of my comfort zone and adapt my communication style. While Cyrill's cultural profile aligns with a low-context and task-based framework, his reality as a non-native English speaker meant he naturally required more time to process, translate, and express complex technical concepts. Because we were working heavily on an individual basis via text, our Teams channel was often quiet. Initially, I found myself uncertain about our momentum, wondering if the project was stalling due to this deliberate pace.

In previous academic group work, I have traditionally taken a more passive role, preferring to let others pull the project forward. However, realizing we had a strict deadline to meet, I recognized that I needed to change my approach. Knowing that Cyrill deeply values explicit, highly structured communication, I adjusted my style to become more proactive. I stepped into a coordinator role, regularly reaching out to ask for progress updates while simultaneously providing clear, direct status updates of my own work.

This was an entirely new experience for me, and it proved to be incredibly rewarding. Instead of waiting for things to happen, I actively managed our linear timeline. By shifting from my usual passive stance to a more forward-leaning, communicative role, I learned how to successfully bridge Cyrill's need for linguistic processing time with our shared Swiss preference for task efficiency and explicit execution.

Research & Content Reflection

Engaging with the research for this assignment fundamentally altered my perspective on how language operates within global development teams. Prior to this project, I viewed English simply as a universal, neutral tool for coding—an industry standard that everyone adapts to over time. However, uncovering the quantitative reality of the "hidden burden" challenged this assumption. I was particularly fascinated by a 2026 study from MDPI, which demonstrated that students using English as an Additional Language (EAL) experience a significantly higher intrinsic cognitive load when navigating programming keywords compared to native speakers. Reading this immediately resonated with my own background as a former apprentice. I recalled the early days of my training, realizing that I wasn't just learning logic; I was expending extra mental energy navigating words like `class`, `if`, or `else` whose natural English meanings simultaneously competed with their technical functions.

In our project, Cyrill and I balanced empirical evidence and personal opinion smoothly. Because the data so accurately mirrored our own lived experiences as Swiss developers, we found ourselves agreeing entirely with our sources; nothing in the data struck us as false or contradictory to our realities. We successfully anchored our perspectives in solid data, such as the fact that English dominates 49.6% of web content and that global teams face measurable communication delays.

This research directly links to Erin Meyer's Communicating Scale (Low-Context) and our first friction point: the "Clarity Gap". In Western tech hubs, a low-context style is favored because it is explicit and direct. However, when a manager delivers ultra-direct feedback to a non-native developer, they often fail to account for the listener's internal cognitive load. The developer is not just processing the critique; they are actively expending mental energy navigating a linguistic barrier, meaning true communication clarity is impossible without considering this processing tax.

Self-Evaluation

Recording this podcast tested my real-time communication skills. My main strength was my ability to adapt my speaking fluidity during the session; while I initially relied on filler words, the longer the podcast went, the more comfortable I became, drastically reducing my use of words like "eeeh" or "mmmm" to maintain a clearer delivery.

Conversely, my primary difficulty lay in real-time structuring, specifically regarding my preparation of facts and figures, which directly caused an awkward ending. Because I reviewed our research papers three days prior, an intense academic workload in between

caused me to forget key data points. This cognitive gap left me struggling to recall precise statistics to ground our final arguments, throwing us off blueprint and leaving us completely unsure of how to smoothly wrap up the recording.

To improve, I will implement a "just-in-time" preparation ritual, reviewing all primary facts and figures immediately before going live. I will also create a structured cheat sheet with pre-written closing blueprints to ensure a decisive conclusion.

Appendix

A: Video

The Video is upload with the worksheet or found here: [engpra_podcast.mp4](#)

B: Bulletlist of core disscussion points

- Introduction, Hook & Context Setup
- The Data: Dominance vs. The Non-Native Majority
- The Deep Dive: Cognitive Load & "Hidden Burden
- Cultural Clashes: Meyer's Scales & Friction Points
- Workplace Dynamics: Meeting Equity & Career Hierarchies
- Strategic Solutions & Closing Thoughts

C: Screenshots of collaboration tools

Engpra Shared Prep Assignment2

Search for tools, help, and more (Option + Q)

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Niks Key Facts and statistics

- **Web Content Dominance:** As of May 2026, English is used as the primary content language for **49.6%** of all websites. By comparison, the next most frequent languages, Spanish and German, account for only **6.0%** each.
https://w3techs.com/technologies/overview/content_language
- **The Non-Native Majority:** While English is the "lingua franca," the global developer population is heavily concentrated in non-native speaking regions. Countries with "Moderate" to "Very Low" English proficiency—such as France, Italy, Brazil, and Japan—represent a significant and growing portion of the 177 countries participating in major tech surveys.
<https://survey.stackoverflow.co/2025/developers#profile-country-all-countries>
- **The "Hidden Burden":** Research published in **MDPI (April 2026)** found that students using English as an Additional Language (EAL) experience a **significantly higher intrinsic cognitive load** when identifying and using programming keywords compared to native speakers.
 - **Keyword Confusion:** EAL developers struggle more with "re-purposed" English words (like `class`, `if`, or `else`) because they must navigate the language's natural meaning simultaneously with its technical function.
<https://www.mdpi.com/2227-7102/16/4/657>
- In a survey of experienced project managers, it was found that the **transfer of Western relationship business principles** (which are typically low-context and task-based) is often **'questionable' and 'surrounded by risks'** when applied to high-context cultures like China
<https://www.mdpi.com/2071-1050/12/18/7588>

Niks Friction Points

Friction Point 1: The "Clarity Gap" in Code & Communication

In low-context cultures (like the US or Germany), "good" communication is explicit and simple. However, a high-context developer (e.g., from Japan or Brazil) might find such directness blunt or unnecessary, especially when they are already struggling with the "Hidden Burden" of translating technical concepts like `class` or `if/else`.

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Podcast Blueprint: 15-Minute Chronological Outline		
Time	Segment	What to Say / Focus On
00:00 - 02:00	1. Introduction, Hook & Context Setup	Introduce yourselves, state your topic (Option B), and establish your baseline Swiss cultural lens.
02:00 - 05:00	2. The Data: Dominance vs. The Non-Native Majority	Analyze the massive linguistic imbalance in tech using global website data and Stack Overflow developer demographics.
05:00 - 08:30	3. The Deep Dive: Cognitive Load & "Hidden Burden"	Discuss how English keywords impact non-native brain processing using recent educational and technical research.
08:30 - 11:30	4. Cultural Clashes: Meyer's Scales & Friction Points	Layer in Erin Meyer's frameworks (Communicating and Trusting scales) to interpret real-world team friction.
11:30 - 13:30	5. Workplace Dynamics: Meeting Equity & Career Hierarchies	Shift to how fluency differences distort corporate dynamics, meeting participation, and competency perceptions.
13:30 -	6. Strategic Solutions & Closing	Propose explicit management strategies to reduce friction

D: Bibliography

- https://w3techs.com/technologies/overview/content_language
- <https://www.mdpi.com/2227-7102/16/4/657>
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- <https://ubwp.buffalo.edu/gse-srs-2022/wp-content/uploads/sites/182/2022/03/Syposium-poster-Enser.pdf>
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- <https://escp.eu/thechoice/choose-to-lead/beyond-english-why-language-diversity-is-a-hidden-business-superpower/>